

Alexia Putellas

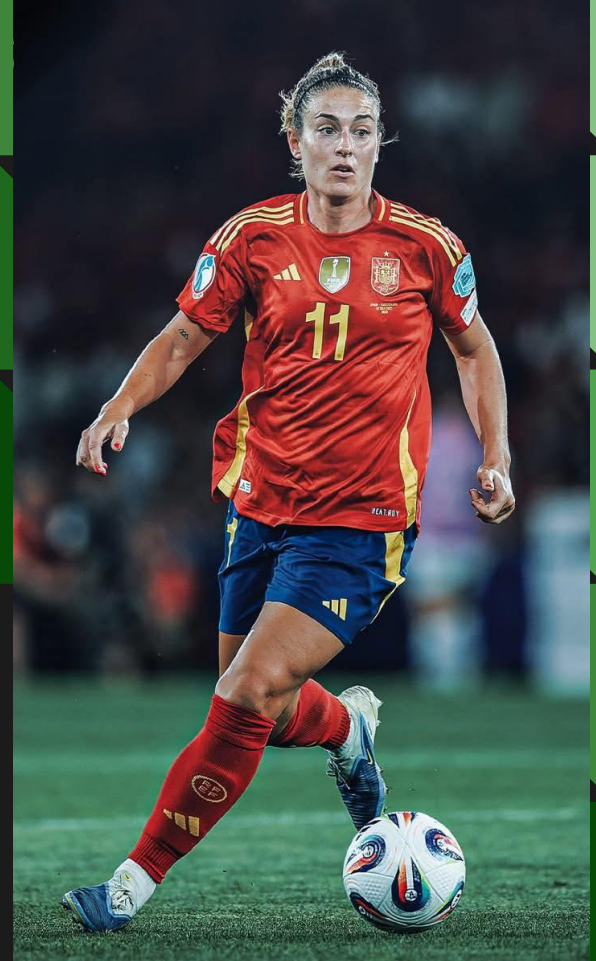
UEFA Women's Euro 2025



Hypothesis

Alexia provided critical playmaking abilities that secured Spain's undefeated group stage during the 2025 Women's Euro, while teammate, and eventual Player of the Tournament, Aitana Bonmati was recovering from illness.

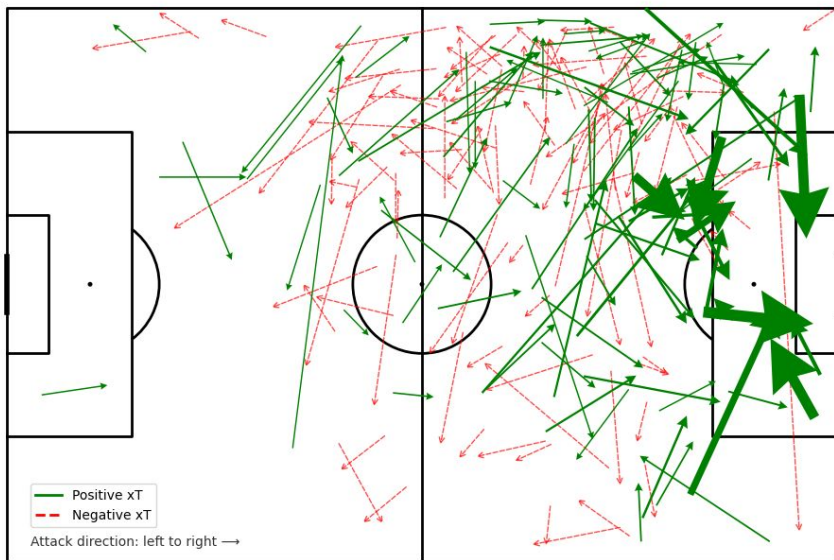
Alexia led a strong Spanish attack on the left side during Spain's group stage matches, which resulted in her scoring 3 goals and 4 assists in addition to being named Player of the Match for Spain's first 2 victories. The 2 time Ballon d'Or Féminin winner was the anchor that ensured their dominance until Aitana returned to full strength during the quarter finals, and Spain's attack shifted to the right side.



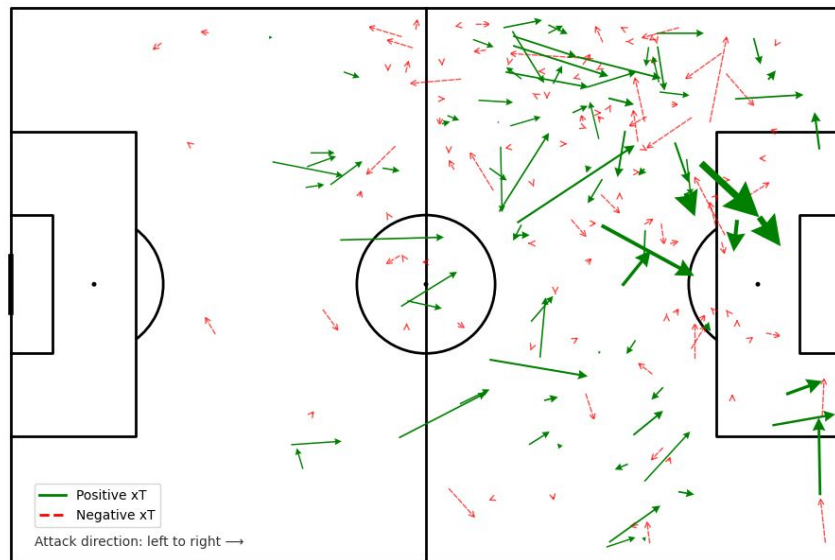
Alexia Putellas: xT Gained In Group Stage

In the group stage, Alexia completed passes and had successful carries from the left attack with positive expected threat (xT) scores, with several dangerous advances into the penalty area.

0.926 xT gained from 172 passes in the attacking half



0.184 xT gained from 182 carries in the attacking half

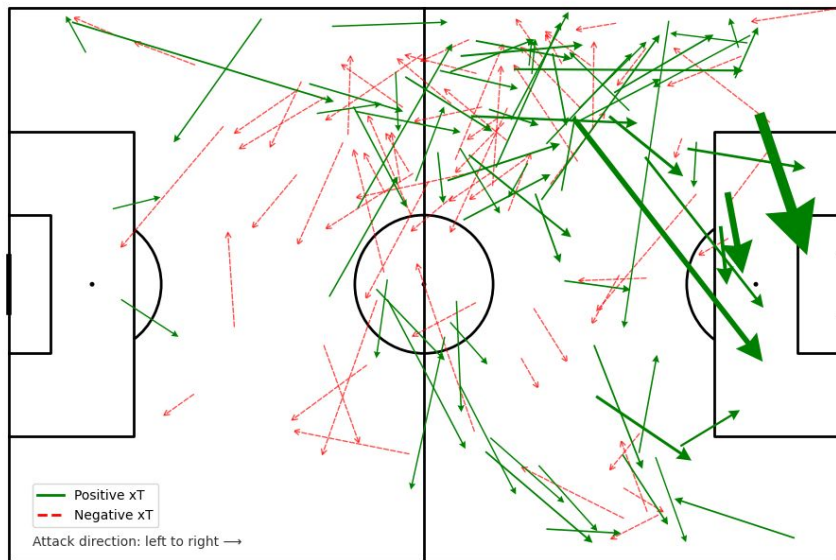


Arrow size is proportional to xT gained for positive xT

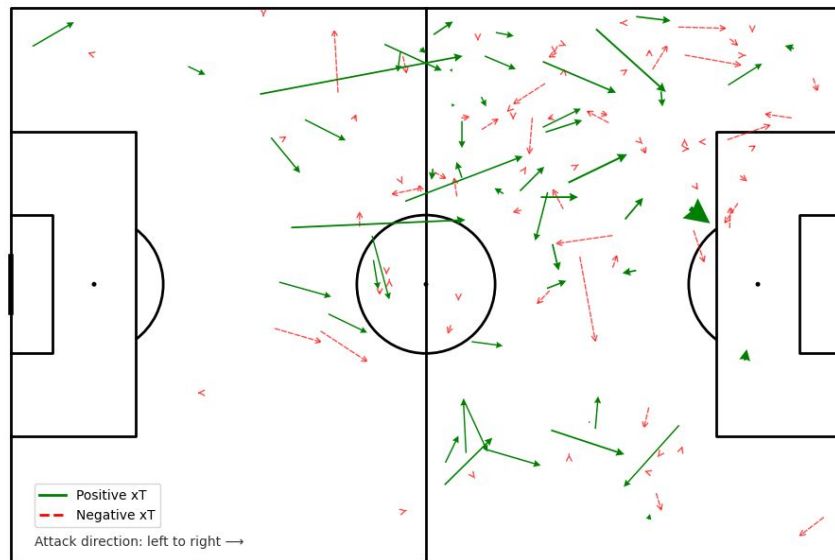
Alexia Putellas: xT Gained In Knockout Stages

In the knockout stages, as Spain's work load shifted more to Aitana on the right side, Alexia's number of contributions and xT gained were lower than the group stage.

0.362 xT gained from 99 passes in the attacking half



0.005 xT gained from 109 carries in the attacking half

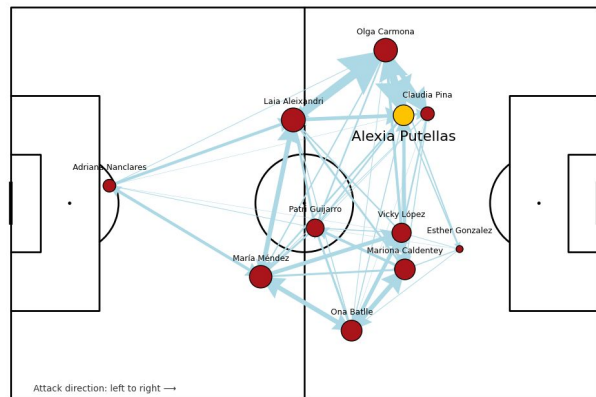


Arrow size is proportional to xT gained for positive xT

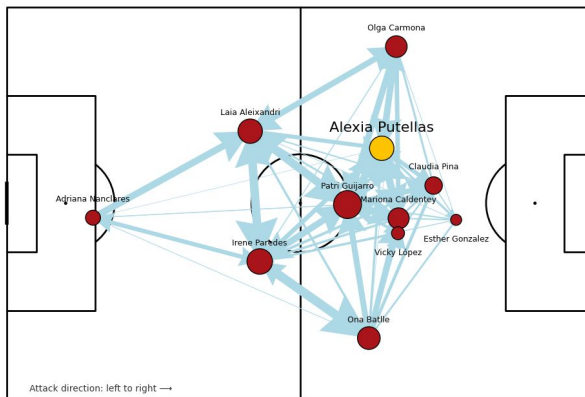
Spain Group Stage Passing Network

During the 3 group stage matches, Spain attacked on the left side utilizing Alexia as an anchor for the playmaking.

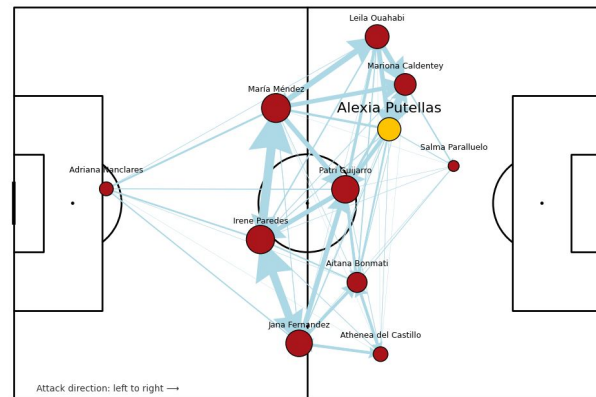
Spain v Portugal, GS1



Spain v Belgium, GS2



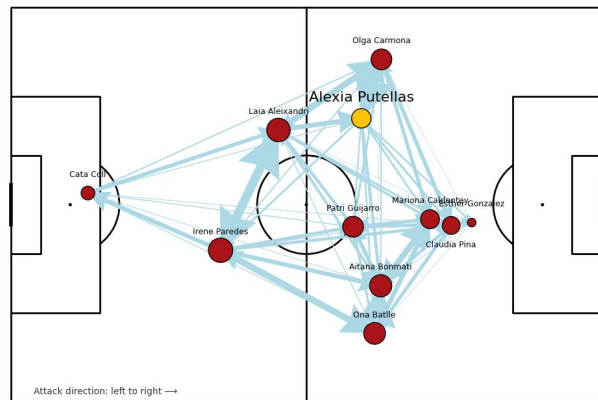
Spain v Italy, GS3



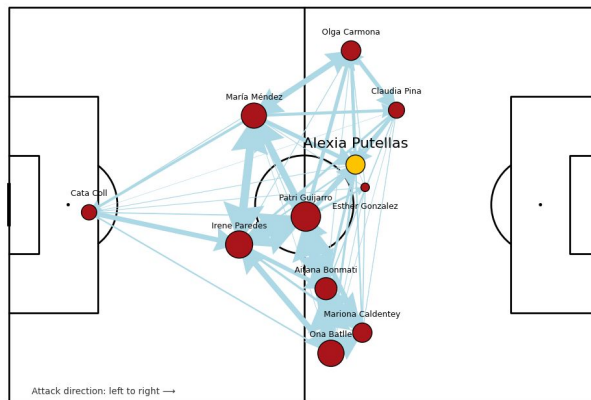
Spain Knockout Stages Passing Network

Starting with the Quarter-final match, Spain's attacking pattern shifted more to right side, with more passing going through Aitana. Alexia still maintained a high attacking position on the pitch.

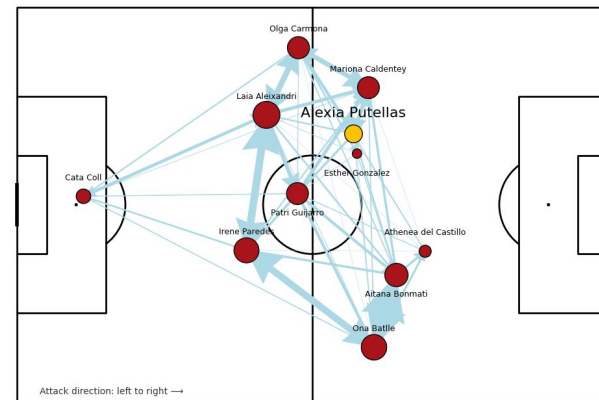
Spain v Switzerland, Quarter-final



Spain v Germany, Semi-final



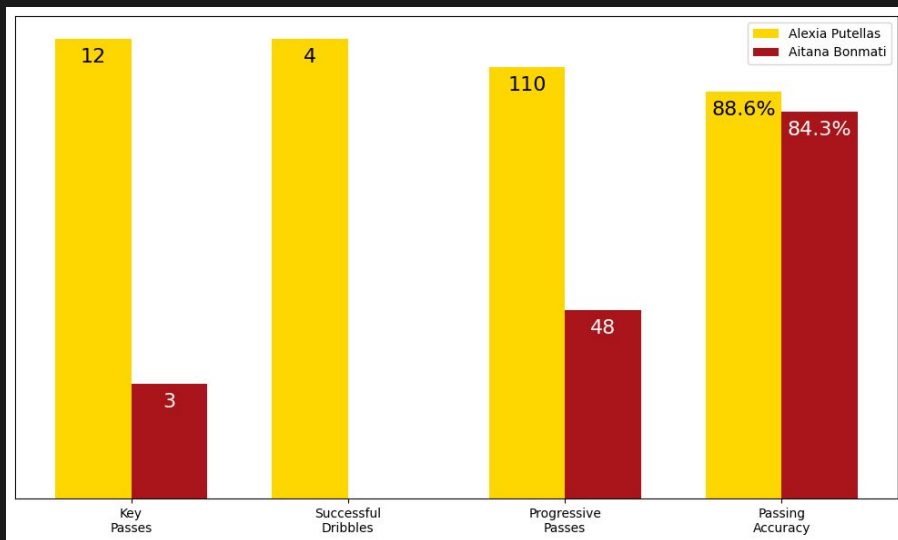
Spain v England, Final



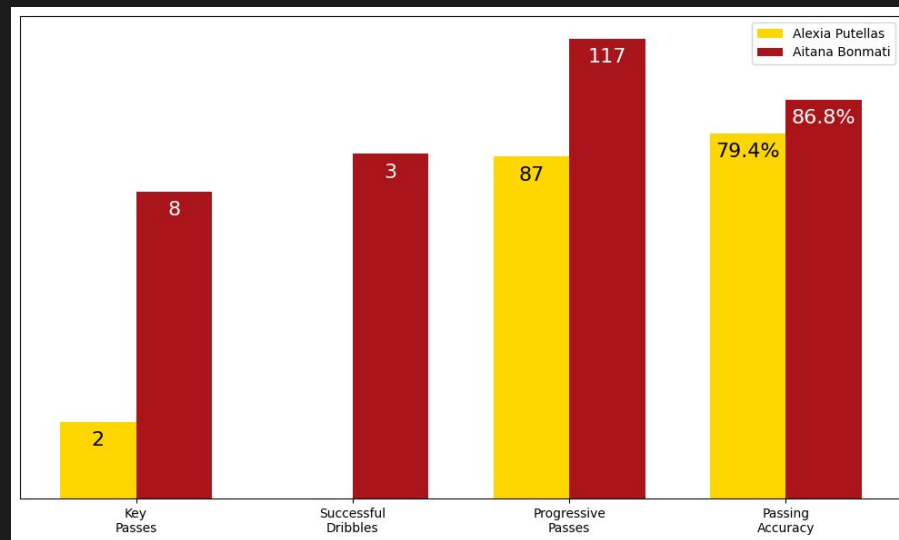
Player Stats

In the group stage, Alexia was able to create valuable actions on her left side at the same level that Aitana produced when the attacking strategy shifted to the right. This offensive production led to successful wins which ensured Spain's spot in the knockout stage.

Group Stage



Knockout Stages



Appendix

Implementation

Statsbomb data for the 2025 UEFA Euro tournament was used:

<https://github.com/statsbomb/open-data>

Expected threat (xT) values were generated by the socceractions Python package. xT values were calculated for the 2025 Euro tournament from Statsbomb data using a 32 x 24 grid.

<https://github.com/ML-KULeuven/socceraction>

Metrics

Expected Threat (xT): a measure of how much the starting coordinates of a player's action (such as a pass, dribble, or carry) increases their team's probability of scoring.

Key Passes: the final pass or pass-cum-shot that leads directly to a teammate attempting a shot on goal.

Successful Dribbles: an intentional attempt by a player with the ball to beat an opposing player using skill or movement.

Progressive Passes: a pass which advances the ball towards the opponent's goal in the opponent's half of the pitch.

Passing Accuracy: percentage of successfully completed passes out of all attempted passes.